Invoice processing for Acme Corp

Design decisions, a demo walkthrough, how the outcomes changed as each stage was built, and what was left out.

Companion to the repository's README. Every figure here is reproduced offline from the recorded model replies, with no API key. Figures as of 12 November 2026; 334 tests pass.

6	6	5	3
paid without a person, $26,325.00	held for a named person	rejected, each with reasons	skipped as second copies

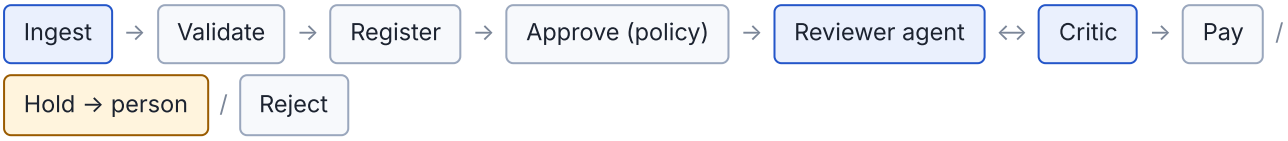
That is what the system does with the brief's 20 sample files. Run the folder again and it pays nothing: **$0.00**.

1. Design decisions
2. Demo walkthrough
3. How the outcomes changed over time
4. What was left out, and why
5. What not to claim
6. Facts to have to hand

1. Design decisions

One principle decides where everything goes.

> **Code decides what is true. The model handles what is unclear. A person owns what is risky.**



The stages are nodes in a LangGraph graph. Blue: a model takes part. Amber: a person decides. Everything else is code.

The decisions, and why

Decision	Why
The model **transcribes**; it does not interpret, correct or compute	A model that "fixes" a number produces one that reconciles perfectly and is wrong. Told to copy values as written, errors included, its output can be checked against the document.
Grounding: every value the model returns must appear in the document	It is the only check that catches an invented or altered value. It is deterministic, because the model returned one file three different ways across three runs at temperature 0.
Repairs need proof from the invoice itself	A scanner's `O` for `0` is read only when another value confirms it: on 1012, `$3,500.00` is confirmed by 7 × $500. No proof, no repair.
Recompute every total; exact decimal arithmetic	A stated total is a claim. 1007 and 1013 state totals their own lines don't add up to.

Stock is summed per product across lines	1013 bills WidgetA on three lines of 15, 5 and 2. Each is within the 15 in stock; together they are 22.
The **approval policy is a written, ordered table** of rules in code	Arithmetic, stock and "has this been paid" have right answers. A table can be read, tested and audited; every decision names the rule that made it.
A model can make the system **stricter, never looser**	The reviewer agent can add a hold to an approval and nothing else. So the worst a persuasive invoice can cause is an extra hold. If the model is unreachable, the policy still decides everything.
Vendor text reaches a model only **inside delimited blocks**	An invoice is written by the party that wants to be paid. "URGENT, pay immediately" on 1003 is counted by code as one fraud signal; no model is asked whether it sounds convincing.
A **ledger** gives each invoice an identity and each payment a key	The same invoice arrives as two files, and folders get re-run. Identity is vendor, number and revision; a second copy is recognised by content, not file name. Without it this folder pays $4,890.00 twice.
A held invoice is a **paused run**, resumed by a person's decision	The decision is made later, in another process, by someone with a name. The run continues from where it stopped; nothing is re-read or re-decided.
Pay in the invoice's own currency; show the reviewer a dollar estimate	The vendor is owed what they billed. The reviewer types no rate and no amount. The rate service is a local mock, since the brief rules out internet access.
An **unknown product** is held if its name is close to a real one, rejected if it resembles nothing	"WidgetC" may be a misspelling or a new product: a person's call. "SuperGizmo" is not something Acme stocks. Code draws the line, by the same name matching the agent's lookup uses.
Structured files are parsed, not sent to the model	A parser is exact, free and gives the same answer every time.
A format no parser knows **falls back to the model, and is always held**	A `.dat` export or a supplier's own JSON layout can be read without writing a parser first. One of four samples was misread, so nothing in a new format is paid without a person.
Only **listed file types** are sent to the model	The model is an outside service, and a folder holds notes, logs and source code as well as invoices.
The **review screen adds no rules** of its own	Deciding calls the same function as before, so what may be approved and what is paid are decided in one place. Vendor text is written to the page as text, never as HTML.
Model replies are **recorded and replayed**	The whole system runs offline with no key, tests are repeatable, and a re-recording that behaves differently fails a test.

Where the model is used, and what stops it going wrong

Use	What it does	What fences it
Extraction	Transcribes a TXT, PDF or unfamiliar file into a fixed JSON schema	Grounding. A value not in the document is sent back with the specific complaint, three attempts at most. A retry that drops data is never used.

Reviewer agent	Chooses lookups (stock, similar products, a vendor's history), recommends, writes the reason a person reads	Its authority is fixed in code: it can add a hold. It cannot approve, reject or pay. A hold it adds can only be released by a person.
Critic	Looks for claims in that reason the evidence doesn't support	Checks in code run first and stand on their own: every figure must be in the invoice, the flags or a lookup result. Two rounds at most.

2. Demo walkthrough

Each step has the command, what to point at, how to say it, and what not to claim. Use a ledger of its own for the demo (`demo.db`; delete it to start over).

The whole folder, and that it is paid once

```
python main.py --invoice_path=data/invoices --offline --ledger demo.db --checkpoints demo-cp.db > /dev/null   # first run
python main.py --invoice_path=data/invoices --offline --ledger demo.db --checkpoints demo-cp.db > /dev/null   # second run
```

	First run	Second run
Paid	6 invoices, $26,325.00 (1001, 1004, 1006, 1010, 1011, 1015)	0
Held	6 (1002, 1004 revised, 1005, 1012, 1014, 1016)	
Rejected	5 (1003, 1007, 1008, 1009, 1013)	
Skipped as a duplicate	3 (second copies of 1011, 1012, 1013)	3
Already processed		17

- **Duplicates.** 1011, 1012 and 1013 each arrive in two formats. The second copy is recognised by content and skipped. Without that, 1011 would be paid twice.
- **1004's revision is held.** The original ($1,890.00) is paid first; the revision ($5,940.00) then arrives and is held for the $4,050.00 difference.
- **1003 is rejected on four fraud signals,** each from a check in code: an item with no stock, a due date of "yesterday", "URGENT... penalties", a request for a wire.
- **1012 is held although nothing on it is wrong any more.** It is $25 under the $10,000 limit and carries repairs and other warnings.

HOW TO SAY IT
Nothing is paid twice, whether the same invoice arrives as a second file or the whole folder is run again.

WHAT NOT TO CLAIM
That payments are real or retried. The mock payment always succeeds. What is tested is that a payment which never confirmed is not blindly sent again.

Three invoices that tell the story

1002: the model made a mistake, was told, and fixed it. `python main.py --invoice_path=data/invoices/invoice_1002.txt --offline`

- Attempt 1 put the invoice total ($15,000.00) on the line item and was rejected by the grounding check. Attempt 2 is fully grounded.
- The judge is code. It is still held, for the right reasons: 20 GadgetX against 5 in stock, and over $10,000.

1012: scanner damage, read only where the invoice proves it. `...invoice_1012.txt --offline`

- The model copied `$3,500.00` and `26-Jan-2026` exactly as written. Code read both, each with its proof on the flag.
- "Widget A" and "Gadget X" were matched to the inventory's names, so stock was checked.

1013: every line passes, the invoice does not. `...invoice_1013.pdf --offline`

- Summed per product: 22 WidgetA against 15, 18 WidgetB against 10, 9 GadgetX against 5.
- The stated total is $22,562.80; lines plus tax come to $22,512.80. Self-correction left it alone: the model copied the document faithfully, and the document is wrong.

Self-correction, measured

```
python -m extraction.report data/invoices
```

	Without	With
Flags that would hold an invoice, across the 20 files	41	32
Model calls, for the 10 TXT and PDF files	10	11
Files improved / worse / unchanged		3 / 0 / 17

HOW TO SAY IT

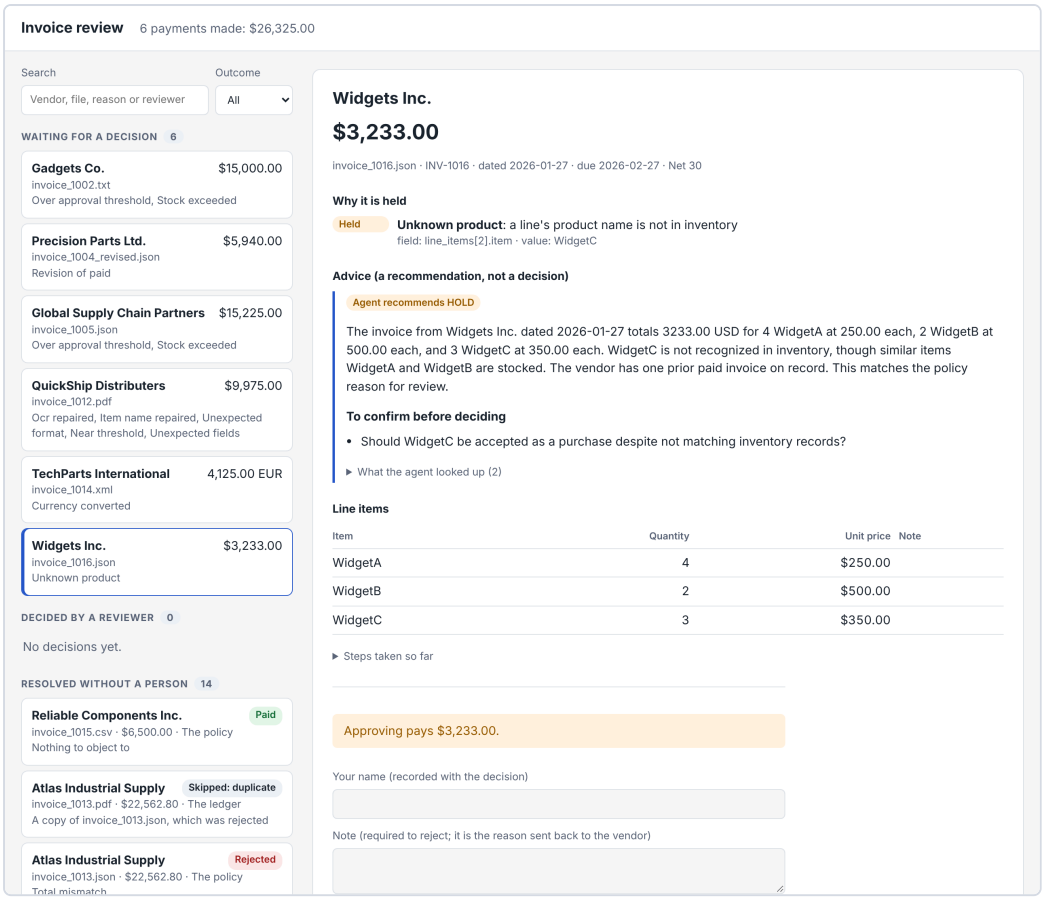
Self-correction removed nine problems that were the model's or the scanner's, for one extra model call, and changed nothing on the invoices that are wrong in themselves.

WHAT NOT TO CLAIM

A success rate. Ten text files with one real retry shows it worked here and did no harm.

The review screen: a person decides

```
python -m web --ledger demo.db --checkpoints demo-cp.db      # then open http://127.0.0.1:8000
```



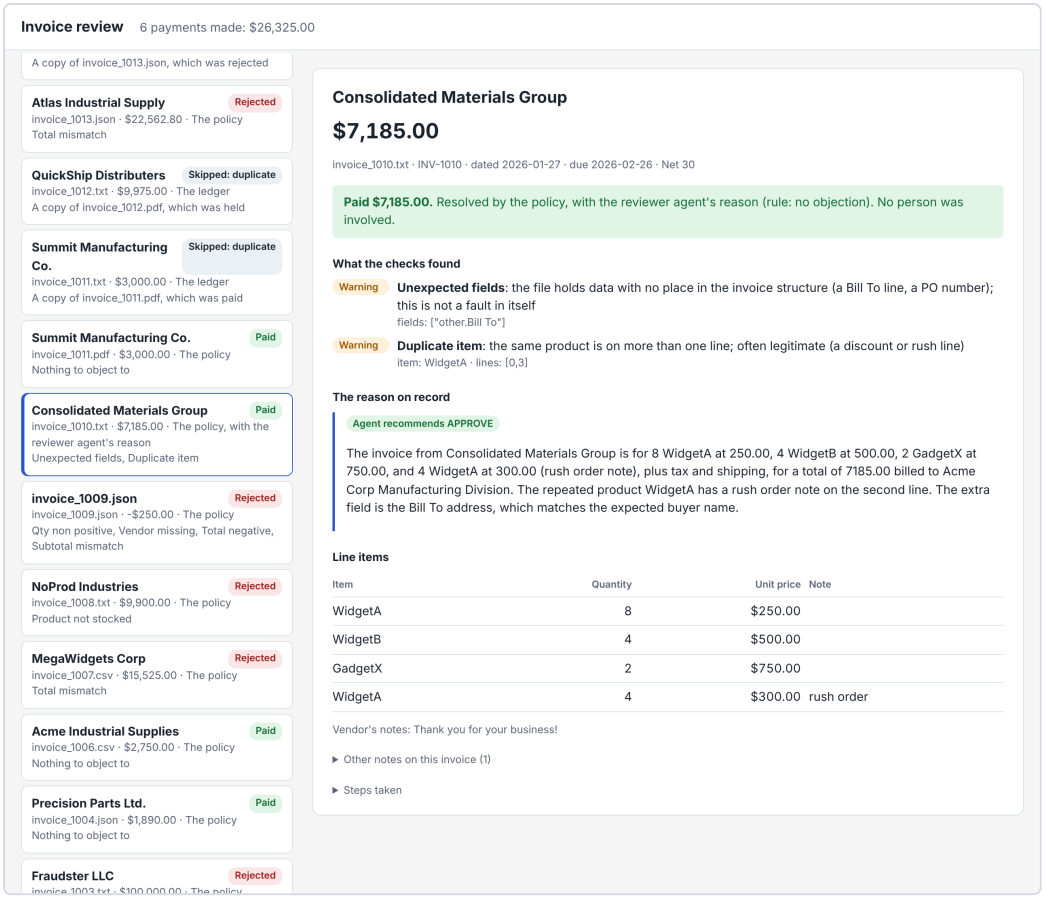
The queue on the left; one held invoice with its flags explained, the agent's advice and the decision form on the right.

- **`main.py` has exited.** Each held invoice is a run saved mid-flight; the screen is a separate process that picks one up and lets it finish.
- **Approve Precision Parts Ltd. (1004 revised):** it pays $4,050.00, the difference, because $1,890.00 already went out.
- **Approve TechParts International (1014):** listed as 4,125.00 EUR (about $4,480.16); it pays 4,125.00 EUR. The reviewer types nothing but a name.
- **Reject one with no note** to show the refusal: a rejection's note is what goes back to the vendor.
- **Search and filter.** Type `15,000` or `stock exceeded`; set the outcome to Rejected. The lists show "5 of 14".

HOW TO SAY IT

The system never asks a person to do what it can do, and never does what a person should decide. A model can make it stricter; only a named person can release a hold.

What the application resolved by itself



The "Resolved without a person" list, with 1010 open: paid by the policy, with the reviewer agent's reason on record.

- Every invoice paid, rejected or skipped without a person is listed with who resolved it (the policy, the policy with the agent's reason, or the ledger) and why.
- Opening one shows the same evidence as a held invoice, read-only, and how it ended.

The reviewer agent: looks things up, can only add caution

```
python main.py --invoice_path=data/invoices --offline --ledger demo2.db --trace 2>&1
>/dev/null | grep '"reviewer"'
```

- **1016.** The agent chose two lookups itself: products like WidgetC (it found WidgetA and WidgetB) and the vendor's history (one earlier invoice, paid). Its question: is WidgetC something we mean to order? Compare 1008, whose product names resemble nothing in inventory: code rejects it and no model is called.
- **1010.** The policy approves it with two warnings. The agent reads them and agrees: the higher price on the second WidgetA line is the vendor's stated rush order, and the Bill To line is Acme's own division.

HOW TO SAY IT

The model can add a hold and advise a person. It cannot approve, reject or pay, and that is enforced in code, so nothing a vendor writes can talk it into paying.

Two true stories, both found by reading real output and not by tests:

- Its first replies suspected four invoices of being duplicates of themselves. The cause was a lookup tool that listed the invoice under review in the vendor's history.
- It then held 1010, asking why WidgetA had two prices (the line said "rush order") and who "Acme Corp Manufacturing Division" was. Its instructions had never said it works for Acme.

Both are the same lesson: when an agent gets something wrong, look first at what it was given.

The critic: checking the reasons a reviewer reads

```
python main.py --invoice_path=data/invoices --offline --ledger demo3.db --trace 2>&1
>/dev/null | grep '"critic"'
```

- **1010 was sent back by a check in code:** two flag codes had been written into the text. The revision describes them in words. No model was needed to catch it.
- **The loop ends on a counter,** two passes at most. It is the graph's only backward edge.
- **No outcome changed, and none can.** The critic checks the reason. It cannot undo a hold.

WHAT NOT TO CLAIM
That the model critic is reliable. In its first two recordings it sent four assessments back on objections that didn't hold up. The checks in code are the dependable part.

A format nobody has seen before

```
python main.py --invoice_path=data/unfamiliar --offline --ledger demo-new.db --trace 2>&1
>/dev/null | grep '"ingest"'
```

File	What it is	Outcome
`invoice_3004.dat`	Pipe-separated lines with no labels: `HDR|INV-3004|Coastal Bearings Co.|...`	Read correctly in one attempt; held
`invoice_3001.json`	JSON with a supplier's own field names	Read correctly; held
`invoice_3003.xml`	XML with a different root element	Read correctly; held
`invoice_3002.csv`	Other column names, the grand total repeated on every row	**Misread, and rejected**

- **The CSV is the one to dwell on.** The model took the repeated total for each line's amount. Every value it returned is in the file, so grounding passed. The arithmetic didn't reconcile, so the policy rejected it.
- **Nothing in a new format is paid without a person.** Three are held; one is rejected.

HOW TO SAY IT
The model lets the system read what nobody wrote a parser for. The checks in code decide whether to believe it.

WHAT NOT TO CLAIM
That the fallback is reliable: one of four was misread. What is reliable is that a misreading which breaks the arithmetic is caught, and one that happens to reconcile is held for a person, not paid.

Watching one invoice move through the pipeline

```
python main.py --invoice_path=data/invoices/invoice_1003.txt --offline --trace > /dev/null
```

One line per stage as it finishes: how the file was read, the flags found, the decision with its rule and reasons, and the branch taken.

3. How the outcomes changed over time

The same 20 sample files, run through the system at each point in its construction. Each row shows what a stage is for by what it changed.

Stage added	Commit	What happens to the 20 files	What changed, and why
Checks and repairs only	`d6b6d14`	No decisions yet. Worst flag per file: 4 block, 6 review, 3 warn, 5 notes only, 2 none	The system can say what is wrong with an invoice, not what to do about it
Policy	`994d0ec`	**8 approved, 7 held, 5 rejected.** Approved invoices total $35,265.00	Flags become decisions
Ledger and payment	`40d715d`	**6 paid ($26,325.00), 7 held, 4 rejected, 3 skipped**	Invoices are compared with each other. $8,940.00 the policy alone approved is not paid; $4,890.00 of it would have been paid twice
Review queue	`460d953`	Same outcomes. Held invoices now wait for a person	A hold stops being a dead end
Rate service	`5f324b7`	Same outcomes. 1014 is listed with a dollar estimate and paid in euros when released	A foreign-currency invoice can be approved like any other
Reviewer agent, first recording	`493ac7d`	**5 paid ($19,140.00), 8 held**	The model added a hold to 1010. It was wrong to
Agent told who the buyer is	`a5d6c6a`	**6 paid ($26,325.00), 7 held**	1010 is paid again. The model had been missing context
Critic, first recording	`e3d4d80`	Same outcomes. 4 of the agent's 8 assessments sent back once	The reasons a reviewer reads are checked. No decision changed
Critic, after its review	`b6009c7`	Same outcomes. 1 of 8 sent back, by a check in code	The critic was told what it had been missing; a hold the agent adds can no longer be undone
Unknown products split	`5ed41ad`	**6 paid, 6 held, 5 rejected, 3 skipped**	A rule change: 1008 (resembles nothing in stock) moves from held to rejected; 1016 (close to a real product) stays held
Review screen	`7e5844a`	Same outcomes. Decisions move from the command line to the browser	The person deciding sees the flags explained, the agent's advice and what approving pays
Resolved list, search, filters	`43acd68`, `2149c53`, `e151b15`	Same outcomes. Every finished run is logged and can be opened	What the application did by itself becomes visible and searchable
Model fallback	`c84f37c`	The 20 are unchanged. Four new files in unknown formats: 3 held, 1 rejected	A format with no parser can be read, and is never paid without a person

Policy: two files move against their worst flag

Invoice	Worst flag	Policy outcome	Why they differ
1003	Review	**Rejected**	No single flag blocks it. Four fraud signals together do
1012	Warning	**Held**	Nothing on it is wrong once repaired. It is $25 under the limit and carries other warnings; that combination is held

Ledger: the same invoice, twice

Approved by the policy alone: $35,265.00. Paid with the ledger: $26,325.00. The difference, $8,940.00, is 1011's second copy ($3,000.00) and 1004's revision ($5,940.00). Of that, $4,890.00 would have been money paid twice ($3,000.00 + $1,890.00); the remaining $4,050.00 is the revision's real difference, which a person releases.

Reviewer agent: one outcome changed, then changed back

This is the only stage where a model can move an outcome, and only from approved to held. Its hold on 1010 was a mistake, and the cause was in what it had been given: nothing told it which company it was reviewing for. On every other invoice it reviews, in every recording, it has recommended what the policy decided. It has never recommended paying something the policy held.

Critic: the reasons are checked, the decisions are not touched

	First recording	After its review
Assessments the agent wrote	8	8
Sent back once	4	1
...by a check in code	2	1
...on the model critic's objection	2	0
Outcomes changed	0	0

The model critic's early objections did not hold up. Each traced to something it had not been told: what a flag means, who the buyer is, that a vendor's own claim is not confirmation. Since the unknown-products change the agent reviews seven invoices; one is sent back, by code, and all seven end accepted.

What code review changed

Each stage was reviewed after it was built, and the findings fixed with a test for each. The ones that changed behaviour, not just code:

- **Two reviewers deciding one invoice at the same moment** could both go through. The first decision recorded now stands and the second is refused.
- **A payment that was sent but did not confirm** looked like a normal approval on the screen. It is now a warning to check with the bank, never "paid".
- **A file in a format nothing reads** was silently skipped when it sat in a folder. It is now reported.
- **Any text file in the folder** would have been sent to the model by the fallback. Only listed types are.

- **A file holding several invoices** would have yielded one and dropped the rest. A batch is refused or flagged.

What stayed the same throughout

- **No stage ever paid something an earlier stage had held or rejected.** Every change after the policy either held or rejected more, or let a named person release a hold.
- **1003, 1007, 1009 and 1013 were rejected from the day the policy was written.** No later stage, and no model, touched them.
- **1001, 1004, 1006, 1011 and 1015 were paid in every version** since payment existed. 1010 is the only one that moved.

4. What was left out, and why

Not built	Why
OCR for scanned images	The sample PDFs have a text layer. A scan is refused with a message saying so.
Reading Word, Excel or image files	Each is reported as an error for a person. Nothing in the brief to build or test against.
Matching to purchase orders and goods receipts	No such data in the brief. It is the first thing to add with real systems: stock on hand is only a stand-in for "quantity we can confirm receiving".
A vendor list	Would catch a changed bank account, a billing currency, and a vendor name spelled two ways.
Real exchange rates	The brief rules out internet access. The rate service is a local mock with made-up rates; a real one is one class with the same method.
Retrying a failed payment	The mock payment always succeeds. An unconfirmed payment is held for a person, never resent blindly.
Processing invoices from the browser	The screen is for decisions. Invoices are still processed by `main.py`.
Logins, deployment, concurrency at scale	Out of scope for a local prototype. A reviewer is whoever types their name, and the screen is served to this machine only.
Full-text search index	Search runs in SQL with one `LIKE` per word, which scans the table. Fine for thousands of rows; SQLite's full-text index is the next step.

Assumptions the brief leaves open

Each is a decision made here, to be confirmed with Acme in the first week.

- **Acme is the buyer.** These are suppliers' invoices that Acme pays.
- **Stock is checked per invoice and doesn't run down** across invoices. The brief's own examples require this.
- **"Over $10K" includes exactly $10,000.** The cautious reading.
- **An invoice that names no currency is in US dollars,** and says so in a note.
- **Files are processed in name order,** so 1004 is paid before its revision is read.

5. What not to claim

- **The percentages don't generalise.** Twenty files, built to be awkward.
- **The agent has not improved a decision.** On these 20 files its one change was an error, since corrected. Its contribution is the written reason and the lookups behind it.
- **The model critic has not earned trust.** Across three recordings it found no real problem, and raised four that weren't until its instructions were corrected.
- **The fallback is not reliable by itself.** One of four unfamiliar files was misread. The checks around it are what make it safe to use.
- **Model output varies between runs,** even at temperature 0. The recordings pin one run.

- **Payments are not real,** and exchange rates are made up.

6. Facts to have to hand

Fact	Where it comes from
All 20 sample files run with no API key, in about a second	`python main.py --invoice_path=data/invoices --offline`
334 tests, about 20 seconds	`pytest`
Nine of ten text files were grounded on the first model attempt	`tests/test_recordings.py`
A document that says "ignore previous instructions" can only write text into a field	`tests/test_extraction.py`
Without the ledger, the policy approves $35,265.00 for this folder; $4,890.00 of it is a double payment	`tests/test_approval.py`, `tests/test_pipeline.py`
With no recordings and no key, every invoice is still decided, by the policy	`tests/test_pipeline.py`
The pipeline diagram in the README is checked against the real graph	`tests/test_pipeline.py`
The brief's own example path, `invoice1.txt`, does not exist	Running it lists the files that do